

premature death at the age of 36, he was hailed by contemporary commentators as “our all-pleasing Britain’s Orpheus” and “the Delight of the Nation and the Wonder of the World.” A century later, he had become “our musical Shakespeare.” None of the composers of his day matched his melodic genius or his inspired eclecticism, which absorbed the fashionable continental styles of Lully and Corelli without sacrificing a quintessential Englishness. His great sensitivity to the rhythms of the English language remains unsurpassed.

Yet the biography of the composer who became a national icon remains fragmentary. What is certain is that he was born into a family of court musicians in 1659, grew up in the shadow of Westminster Abbey, London, and was one of 12 boy trebles in the Chapel Royal. At the age of 18, he was appointed “composer-in-ordinary for the king’s violins.” In 1679, he became organist of Westminster Abbey, and a year or two later he married Frances Peters.